

What “open” actually means

Four different claims that all get called open, and what each one does and does not give you.

FILE CALLED “OPEN”

all three of these ship under the word, and none of them is the defined term

01

FILE

Open weights

you can download and run it

The parameters are yours to fetch and serve. It says nothing about what the licence permits, and nothing about whether you could rebuild the model.

ABOUT ACCESS, NOT LICENCE

02

FILE

The licence

what you may do with it

Three different shapes ship under the same word, and which one you have decides whether the weights you downloaded are usable for what you had in mind.

FILE

Permissive

Reuse with minimal conditions — attribution, a warranty disclaimer, nothing about derivatives.

FILE

Copyleft

Derivatives must carry the same terms. Freedom enforced downstream, not merely granted.

FILE

Community licence

A vendor’s own terms: downloadable weights with conditions open source licences do not allow.

READ IT, DO NOT ASSUME IT

03

FILE

Acceptable use policy

what you may not do with it

Usually incorporated into the licence by reference — so the terms constraining your use can change while the licence you agreed to stays word for word the same.

MOVES WITHOUT THE LICENCE MOVING

04

FILE

Open source AI

the defined term

Under OSI's Open Source AI Definition 1.0 a system qualifies only with data information, training code and parameters. Most things called open source AI do not clear it.

A DEFINITION, NOT A VIBE

WHAT SHOULD SHIP WITH THE MODEL

FILE **Model card** — What it is, what it was meant for, how it was evaluated, and where it should not be used.

WHERE IT CAME FROM

CIRCLE **Provenance** — Evidence about a model, dataset or piece of content, attached to the artifact rather than asserted about it.

MARKING THE OUTPUT

CIRCLE **Watermarking** — Identification embedded in the generated content itself, rather than attached alongside it as metadata.

“Open” is four separate claims wearing one word. Downloadable is not licensed, licensed is not unrestricted, and none of the three is open source.